

Felis nigripes
Black-footed cat



Length 13½–19½ in
(34–50 cm)
Tail 6–8 in
(15–20 cm)
Weight 3¼–6½ lb
(1.5–3 kg)
Location Southern Africa
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



One of the smallest cats, the size of a very small pet cat, this species is pale brown with bold stripes, which thicken on the legs and merge into the all-black undersides of the feet. Prey is likewise small; for example, mice, insects from termites to locusts, spiders, small lizards, and birds. Well adapted to the Karoo, the Kalahari, and other arid regions of southern Africa, it seldom needs to drink water.



Leopardus jacobitus
Andean cat



Location W. South America

Length 23–25 in
(58–64 cm)
Tail 16–19 in
(41–48 cm)
Weight 8¾ lb
(4 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered



Little is known about the habits of the rare Andean, or mountain cat. Small and sturdy, with a long, bushy tail, it has thick, warm, gray-brown fur that is marked with vertical stripes along the upper back, rosette-type spots on the flanks, and bands around the legs and tail. This feline inhabits dry, rocky slopes above the tree line—generally 9,900 ft (3,000 m)—and preys mainly on rodents such as viscachas and formerly chinchillas. Unlike many other cats, this species is not directly at risk from hunting or habitat loss, but hunting threatens some of the prey species on which it depends.

Leopardus guigna

Kodkod



Location W. South America

Length 16½–20 in
(42–51 cm)
Tail 7½–10 in
(19.5–25 cm)
Weight 4½–5½ lb
(1.3–3 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



The smallest cat in the Americas, the kodkod or güiña closely resembles Geoffroy's cat (see below) but with a thicker tail and smaller head. Its coat is black-spotted gray to ocher, with a ringed tail and a dark throat stripe. Found in moist, cool forests in the Andean foothills of Argentina and Chile, it makes its den in bamboo thickets in the understory. Its main prey are rodents such as mice and rats, and lizards, captured on the ground as well as in trees. It probably hunts by day as well as at night.

Leopardus geoffroyi

Geoffroy's cat



Location C. to S. South America

Length 17–35 in
(43–88 cm)
Tail 9–16 in
(23–40 cm)
Weight 4½–18 lb
(1.8–7.8 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Geoffroy's cat, which is sometimes called Geoffroy's ocelot, prefers scrub and shrub to forest and open grassland. It hunts in the branches, on the ground, and in water, for frogs and fish as well as the usual small-cat fare of rodents, lizards, birds, and the (introduced) brown hare. Now

protected, this species was hunted for its yellow-brown to silver-gray fur after the trade in ocelot fur (see panel above, right) declined in the 1980s.

regularly sized and spaced black spots



Leopardus pardalis

Ocelot



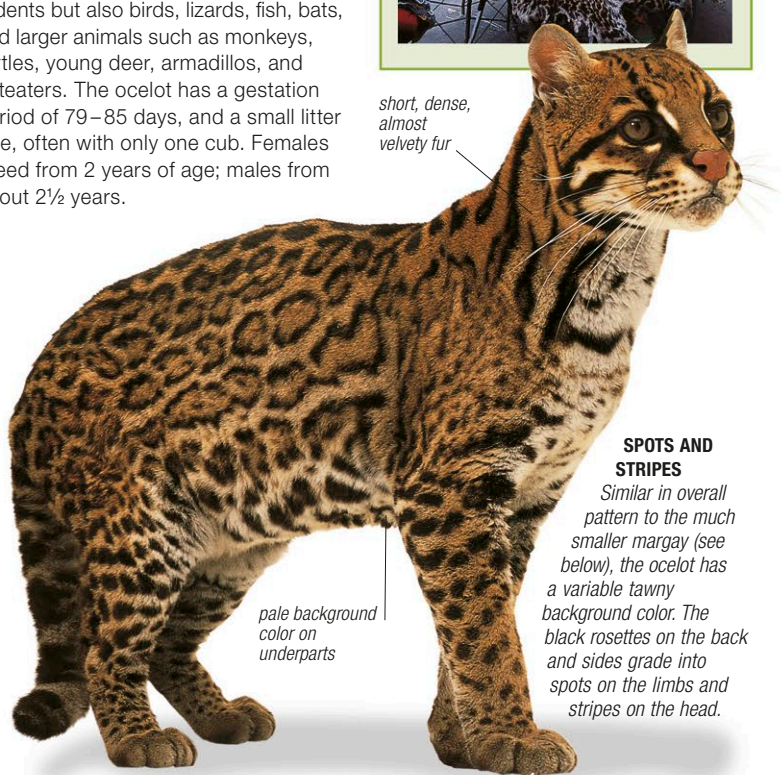
Location S. USA to Central and South America

Length 28–39 in
(72.5–100 cm)
Tail 10–16 in
(25.5–41 cm)
Weight 14–25 lb
(6.5–11.5 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



The chainlike rosettes and spots on this cat's body are highly distinctive. Typically catlike in its nocturnal, solitary, tree-climbing lifestyle, the ocelot is wide ranging and adaptable, living in a variety of habitats from grassland to swamp, as well as most types of forest. It takes a huge variety of prey: chiefly small rodents but also birds, lizards, fish, bats, and larger animals such as monkeys, turtles, young deer, armadillos, and anteaters. The ocelot has a gestation period of 79–85 days, and a small litter size, often with only one cub. Females breed from 2 years of age; males from about 2½ years.

short, dense, almost velvety fur



SPOTS AND STRIPES

Similar in overall pattern to the much smaller margay (see below), the ocelot has a variable tawny background color. The black rosettes on the back and sides grade into spots on the limbs and stripes on the head.

pale background color on underparts

Leopardus wiedii

Margay



Location S. USA to Central and South America

Length 18–31 in
(46–79 cm)
Tail 13–20 in
(33–51 cm)
Weight 5½–8¾ lb
(2.5–4 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Near threatened



The margay has exceptional climbing abilities because of its almost "reversible" rear feet, being able to run headfirst down a trunk or hang from a branch by one paw. Its mainly tree-dwelling prey includes rats, mice, squirrels, possums, young sloths, small birds, and invertebrates such as grubs and spiders. It also occasionally eats fruit. The margay is nocturnal, resting in the safety of a tree fork by day. The

gestation period is 76–85 days and litter size is one, rarely 2. Following the decline in the availability of ocelot fur (see panel, above), margays became one of the most sought-after small cats for the fur trade. Hunting may still continue illegally in a few areas, but the primary threat to the margay is now forest clearance.

